



ILLUSTRATION BY RAJ VERMA

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any spending, while most borrowing, when it happens, is informal—friends, family or limited credit.

The mistake is to confuse delayed commitment with disinterest. Many companies respond by forcing urgency through discounts, influencer amplification or emotional pressure.

That often backfires.

Across categories, Gen Z is optimising for four things: clarity on what it is paying for, control over when and how it commits, consistency in brand behaviour over time, and credibility between promise and performance. This explains why quick commerce

is used frequently for daily needs by over 60% of urban GenZers, while physical retail dominates categories where trust and inspection matter.

It also explains digital behaviour. While Instagram remains the most influential platform, nearly 40% say they only “rarely” or “sometimes” purchase after seeing products on social media.

The implication for CEOs is unavoidable: growth with Gen Z is progressive, not explosive. The companies that win will be those that design for progression, low-risk entry points, transparent value tiers and clear upgrade paths aligned with readiness, not advertising pressure.

This requires a shift in leadership metrics. Acquisition must give way to retention. Quarterly spikes must give way to lifetime value. Brand salience must give way to brand reliability. It also requires restraint. In a Gen Z world, premature premiumisation destroys trust and trust, once lost, is rarely recovered.

This matters because Gen Z is only at the beginning of its economic journey. Over the next decade, it will drive India’s largest wave of first-time asset ownership, premium services adoption and consumption.

In investment terms, Gen Z does not deliver momentum; it delivers duration. That distinction will separate enduring franchises from those that enjoy only temporary relevance.

That brings the conversation back to the boardroom question. Are you building a business that a 22-year-old can start with today and still believe in at 32? Does your model reward caution or punish it?

CEOs who answer these questions correctly will not just win Gen Z market share. They will secure relevance, resilience and renewal for the next decade. That may be the only advantage that truly compounds. **BT**

Views are personal